Veterans Affairs

One-page brief

Priority: 8 of 33 (score 3.5). **FY2026 outlays:** $419B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27 (first written 2026-10-25). Public data only.

Bottom line

VA pairs naturally with DoD. Its service-disabled veteran-owned (SDVOSB) set-aside contracts use the same SAM.gov and FPDS pipeline, and its GI Bill school data let us screen schools. Benefit payment fraud itself (compensation, community care) is mostly hidden from public data.

Exposure

- VA reported $3.92B in improper and unknown payments across 7 programs in FY2025: $1.49B monetary loss and $1.74B unknown. Compensation alone was about $2.3B. (PaymentAccuracy.gov, GAO)
- SDVOSB pass-through and fake-eligibility schemes are recurring VA OIG and DOJ cases.

Public data we can use

- **FPDS / USAspending** VA contracts with set-aside type.
- **SAM.gov** and **SBA VetCert** certification lists.
- **GI Bill Comparison Tool** data (school, enrollment, caution flags).
- **VA OIG reports** and DOJ releases.

Detection plays

1. **SDVOSB fronts:** certified firms that subcontract most work, share officers with non-veteran firms, or appear just before large awards.
2. **School risk:** GI Bill schools with fast enrollment growth, caution flags, or ownership links to schools that closed or were sanctioned.
3. **Community care providers:** cross-match VA community care vendors against HHS-OIG's exclusion list (via the HHS pipeline).

First prototype

Add VA to the DoD contractor screen (same code, VA awards) and a GI Bill school watch list.

Limits

Claims and community care payment details are not public.

Who to take it to

VA's Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization, Veterans Benefits Administration (Education Service), and VA OIG.

Related briefs

dod.pdf (shared contractor pipeline), opm.pdf (benefit payees and death data).

Sources

- PaymentAccuracy.gov: VA
- GAO-26-108694: FY2025 improper payments

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